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What is Accessibility?

Introduction

The web has grown to play an integral role in almost every aspect of our everyday lives. From education, to employment to messaging our friends, we access the web every single day. When content isn't accessible, people with disabilities become excluded from countless amounts of information and opportunities that other people take for granted on a daily basis. Understanding how different people interact with web content, as well as assistive technologies and inclusive design techniques, will allow writers and developers to create content that is usable by everyone.

Accessibility and inclusion go hand-in-hand. According to Laura Kalbag, accessibility is “the degree to which an environment is usable by as many people as possible” (Kalbag). In digital contexts, web accessibility extends this definition to websites, apps, and online media. For professional and technical writers, accessibility is more than a design preference. It is a responsibility. The choices developers make will dictate whether people can access information and engage with digital spaces. This overview of accessibility introduces key concepts that writers should know as they consider accessibility in digital spaces.

What is a Disability?

Before discussing what accessibility really means, it is essential to understand what and who it is for. Disability is not a single, uniform experience. Rather, it is an extremely personal and individual experience. People may have multiple disabilities, or their needs may change depending on the context of the situation they are in. Understanding disabilities is essential to providing people with a truly accessible product or design. In Adobe's Inclusive Design Workshop, they outline several categories of disabilities, each of which affects how people might interact with something within a digital environment. Sensory disabilities affect a person's sight, hearing, or touch. Physical disabilities impact mobility. Intellectual,

developmental, and neurological disabilities can regulate cognitive ability and affect how people interact with information. Finally, psychological disabilities affect people's well-being and mental health. Through each category, the reading emphasizes that there are levels of severity for each disability. For example, two people might be considered legally blind, but one might still have “residual vision,” like being able to see light, while the other does not (Adobe 11). The reading also highlights self-adaptation, noting that people with disabilities often develop their own strategies to complete tasks when systems fail them. To achieve truly inclusive design, it is important to not only understand these strategies but also support them through thoughtful design and writing.

Universal vs. Accessible Design

Once the needs of everyone have been considered, it's time to implement them into your inclusive design. Before doing so, it is essential to understand the difference between “accessible design” and “universal design.” According to Kalbag, accessible design focuses specifically on people with disabilities and their needs, whereas “universal design is the design of products and environments to be usable by all people, to the greatest extent possible, without the need for adaptation or specialized design” (Kalbag). In practice, these approaches overlap. Assistive technologies such as screen readers, keyboard navigation, speech recognition, switch inputs, and more are essential for many people with disabilities, but they also benefit others. For example, many people opt to use closed captions while watching videos, even if they have the ability to hear, because it helps them follow along better.

Why Accessibility Matters

Professional and technical writers play a crucial role in shaping digital experiences for all different types of people. From creating documentation to marketing materials, to journalistic content, to so much more, writers influence how people from every part of the world access information. Accessibility matters because it expands your audience and aligns with both legal and ethical responsibilities. More importantly, it reflects a commitment to equity and inclusivity. When writers adopt inclusive practices, they help ensure that people with disabilities can participate in digital spaces, just as abled people can.

The documentary *Crip Camp* offers a powerful illustration of why this commitment matters in practice. The film shows what an accessible world can look like when people with disabilities are not treated as afterthoughts but rather as full participants. At Camp Jened, disabled teenagers experienced, many for the first time, an environment built around their needs rather than one that forced them to adapt. The camp wasn't "special" because it segregated them; it was transformative because it encouraged autonomy and treated accessibility as a baseline expectation. Seeing this environment in practice makes it clear that accessibility is not theoretical. When barriers are removed, people thrive, connect, and contribute in ways that inaccessible spaces often prevent.

For writers, this lesson translates directly into digital work. Just as the activists in *Crip Camp* fought for ramps, interpreters, and equal access to public buildings, today's digital spaces require their own forms of access—clear structure, readable text, captions, alt text, and compatibility with assistive technologies. These features aren't add-ons. They are the digital equivalents of the ramps and curb cuts that activists demanded in the 1970s and 80s. When writers build accessibility into their content, they help create the kind of inclusive environment that *Crip Camp* shows is both possible and necessary. The more that professional and technical writers embrace accessibility, the closer we get to the kind of world *Crip Camp* envisions: one where everyone has the tools and opportunities to participate fully.

Conclusion

Web accessibility is not an optional add-on. It is a fundamental part of responsible design. By understanding different types of disabilities and embracing inclusive design techniques, writers can create content that welcomes rather than excludes. As *Crip Camp* reminds us, accessibility is ultimately about dignity and equal participation. When professional and technical writers commit to accessibility, they contribute to a more inclusive digital world. One where everyone has the opportunity to engage, learn, and be heard.

Works Cited

Adobe Inclusive Design Workshop: Module 3 — Disability. Adobe, version 0.9, n.d.

“Considering Accessibility.” *Accessibility for Everyone*,
accessibilityforeveryone.site/considering-accessibility/. . Accessed 24 Feb. 2026.